

AR YPO Dinner, Little Rock: Talking Points

Event: "The YPO You Don't Know Yet," Arkansas YPO chapter kickoff dinner **Date:** Wednesday, September 16, 2026 | 6:00 to 9:00 PM CDT **Venue:** Pleasant Valley Country Club, Little Rock, AR **Format:** Cocktails 6:00, dinner 6:30 to 6:45, panel conversation opens around 7:30. Panel of two to three, with a table discussion pause every seven to eight minutes, then one share per table. **Your role:** Panelist. Peer voice, not the YPO pitch. Wendy Lee carries the staff/program overview; you carry the member experience. **Lodging:** Capital Hotel. AR chapter covers the room. Marilyn arranged a car from the hotel to the club, and will drive you back after.

The Read on the Room

This is a kickoff, not a sales meeting. The chapter is rebuilding its calendar around a theme, traveling the state to reconnect members, and the working assumption buried in all the planning emails is this: **people in this room are paying for YPO and don't fully know what they already own.** Lee's ask was not "explain YPO." It was "explain what nobody bothers to read."

Your job tonight is to be the guy who has actually used the thing. You founded a Gold chapter, you chaired a chapter, you sit on REX. You are not a vendor in the room. You are the proof of concept.

Two things are working in your favor: Wendy is there as staff, so the program catalog is covered. And Lee explicitly set the tone in his own words: explain the regions, the regional board, the networks, the trips, GLC and Edge, the sheer size of the organization, and the fact that members can walk into any chapter in the world when they travel. That is your lane.

Who's in the Room

Person	Role	What You Know	How to Play It
Lee Morgan	CEO, The Systems Group (Little Rock). AR YPO member and daychair for this event.	Invited you. Industrial services company: plant services, spray-cooled, contracting, fab & machine, clean air, refractory. He remembers you as a regional chair. He arranged the room at the Capital Hotel. His stated priorities for you: regions, regional board, networks, YPO trips, GLC, Edge, organization scale, and the "visit any chapter" perk.	Treat him as your co-pilot. He owns the chapter, you own the YPO-wide view. Credit him early and publicly for building the event.
Marilyn Porterfield	YPO Arkansas Chapter Manager (ypoarkansas@gmail.com)	Runs the operational side. Built the question list and the table-discussion format. Her specific ask: she wants you and Lee to explain the Chapter Commitment requirements so members understand why she is chasing them for information.	She has set you up with a great agenda. Answer her questions in her order where you can. Give her the Chapter Commitment piece warmly, because she is the one who takes the heat for it.

Person	Role	What You Know	How to Play It
Wendy Lee	YPO Membership Recruitment Manager, Western US Region (Dallas based)	Flying in from Dallas. Has read the plan and is aligned. Said the evening works best as "a candid, conversational discussion with plenty of member interaction," no slides.	Your partner on the panel. Let her take the catalog: M2M, YPO Connect, Concierge, networks, Global Impact. You take the human stories that make the catalog believable. Do not step on each other.
Shelby Meyer	YPO staff, Gold Area / regional officer support	Coordinated the invite chain. Cannot attend. Called you "area officer" and asked whether you could make it.	Money in the bank for credibility if the room knows her. Mention that the region's staff are your first call when a member has a problem.
Arkansas members at the tables	Owners, CEOs, presidents from across the state	Chapter is deliberately touring the state to pull in members from outside Little Rock. Likely heavy on family-owned and industrial businesses. Strategic partners of the chapter include Stephens Inc., Friday Eldredge & Clark, and Simmons Bank , so expect finance and legal leaders in the room too.	These are peers, not prospects. High-achieving, skeptical, busy, and allergic to being pitched.

Purpose of the Evening

The chapter named its own goal: **"The Bridge Year: Linking Leaders Across Arkansas."** Subtitle: **"From Conversation to Connection."** Read that literally. They are trying to move members from knowing YPO exists to actually using it. The panel exists so the room hears, from people who have done it, that the value is real and specific.

Your success metric is not applause. It is that two or three people come up to you during dessert and ask a real question about how to use YPO.

Talking Point Clusters

1. Stop treating YPO like a dues payment. It's a toolset nobody opens.

Main message: The single biggest mistake is paying for the whole platform and using only the monthly meeting.

Suggested phrasing: "The biggest mistake I see new members make is treating YPO like a calendar entry. You show up once a month, you like the people, and you never open the rest of the box. YPO is the one

membership in your life where the boring-sounding stuff is actually the best stuff. The networks. The trips. GLC. Edge. And you've already paid for all of it."

Evidence / texture: Marilyn named M2M as an example she thinks members don't know. YPO Connect is the same story. The catalog is deep and most members never read it.

Source: Marilyn's planning email, Lee's ask.

2. Region and the regional board are the reason your membership gets bigger than your chapter.

Main message: YPO is not a Little Rock club. It is a global organization you happen to enter through Little Rock.

Suggested phrasing: "Here's what I didn't understand early. Your chapter is the front door, not the house. Every chapter sits inside a region, and the region sits inside this enormous, worldwide network. I sit on the Regional Executive Board, and I'll tell you what that seat taught me: the reach is the point. The Global Leadership Conference, YPO Edge, the networks, the trips. Eight thousand people in a room who all run something. And when you travel, you can reach out to the local chapter. Any city, any state, any country. That is a benefit most members never claim."

Evidence / texture: You are the case study. Founder of Lone Star Dallas Gold, former chapter chairman, now REX. Say it plainly and move on. Do not linger on the resume; let it do its work.

Source: Lee's ask, identity/MEMORY.md.

3. The most powerful relationships do not happen on the stage. They happen in the gaps.

Main message: The relationships that matter come out of forum, out of networks, out of shared trips, not out of the monthly program.

Suggested phrasing: "Nobody's most important YPO relationship started at a podium. It started in a forum, or on a trip, or over a meal exactly like this one. Which is why what Marilyn has built into tonight matters. The table conversations are not filler. That's the actual product."

Evidence / texture: This directly reinforces the format Marilyn designed (pause every seven to eight minutes for table talk). Naming it out loud makes the room lean into the exercise instead of waiting it out.

Source: Marilyn's email, chapter theme "From Conversation to Connection."

4. If you're already successful, use YPO for what you cannot buy.

Main message: At this level, the value is not information. It is peers who have already paid the tuition.

Suggested phrasing: "The question I get is, how should I use YPO if I'm already doing well? My answer is that it's not about getting smarter. You're already smart. It's about getting fewer things wrong, with people who are glad to tell you what they got wrong first. That is the only room in your life where nobody is trying to sell you anything."

Evidence / texture: This is the answer to Marilyn's question about "how should someone use YPO if they're already successful." It also quietly frames Improving correctly without naming it: peer counsel, not a pitch.

Source: Marilyn's question list.

5. Chapter Commitment is not nagging. It is what makes the chapter worth joining.

Main message: The requirements Marilyn chases you for are the mechanism that turns a dues list into a real network.

Suggested phrasing: "I want to say one thing about the Chapter Commitment requirements, because Marilyn takes some grief for them. Attendance expectations, email responsiveness. Those aren't bureaucracy. A chapter where 40 percent of members show up is a mailing list. A chapter where most of them show up is a network. The requirements are the price of the thing being worth your time."

Evidence / texture: Chapter Commitment standard in your own notes: 80 percent event attendance, 24-hour email response. Frame it as the floor, not the ceiling.

Source: Marilyn's direct request, identity/MEMORY.md.

Anticipated Q&A

These are Marilyn's own eight questions. Prepare a real answer to each, one or two sentences, then hand it to the room.

Q: What's the biggest mistake new YPO members make? A: They join for the people and then treat it like a subscription. They never open the 80 percent of the platform they already paid for. The fix is embarrassingly simple: pick one network, or one trip, and book it in your first year.

Q: What do the most engaged members do differently? A: They show up before they need something. The people getting the most out of YPO are the ones volunteering to serve on a committee or host a gathering in year one, not year five. YPO rewards giving before taking, and it rewards it fast.

Q: What resource inside YPO is dramatically underused? A: Four of them, in my experience. M2M, where members do real business with each other. YPO Connect, the member platform. The networks, which are open to you regardless of what your chapter is doing. And Concierge, which most members have never called once. Wendy can walk through all of it, and she should.

Q: What's something you wish every member knew? A: That your chapter membership gives you a seat in every chapter in the world. When you travel for work or for fun, reach out to the chapter where you're going. It changes the whole experience of traveling. I've done it, and it's the single most underused perk we have.

Q: Where do the most powerful relationships actually happen? A: Forum first, then shared travel, then tables like this one. Not the stage. If you want the relationships, get into a forum and stay in it, and say yes to one trip a year.

Q: How should someone use YPO if they're already successful? A: As a board of advisors you didn't have to assemble. Use it for the things that keep you up at night, not the things you already know. And be the person who tells a younger member what you got wrong, because that is where the meaning is.

Q: What's the best "I can't believe YPO gave me this" story you've heard? A: Tell a real one from your own chapter building years. If you go with someone else's story, keep it short and specific. The stories land when they are small, not when they are impressive.

Q: What should Arkansas members take advantage of this year? A: The Bridge Year itself. The chapter is coming to you this year instead of asking you to come to Little Rock. Take that deal. Show up in the town you live in, and bring one person with you. And look at GLC and Edge. If you're going to use one big-ticket piece of your membership this year, use it there.

Questions to Ask Others at Your Table

Good dinner conversation, drawn from what the room cares about. Ask these and then actually listen; the asks are the value tonight.

1. "You've been in the chapter a while. What's the one part of YPO you've never gotten around to using?"
 2. "Is your forum still together? What's made it last?"
 3. "Did you get to GLC or Edge yet? What did it do for you?"
 4. "When you travel for business, do you ever reach out to the local chapter? That one changed it for me." (Say this one as an offer, not a quiz.)
 5. "What would make this chapter actually worth your time this year? Not the dues, the time."
 6. "Who's the person in this room you don't know yet?" Then, if you can, make the introduction.
 7. "What's the business looking like going into next year?" (Open, generous, non-transactional. Arkansas members will tell you if they want to.)
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Landmines

- **Do not pitch Improving.** Not once. This room is a YPO chapter, and you are here as a YPO leader. If a business conversation starts, let it be started by them, and keep it to listening and connecting. You have a Texas base and can make introductions across the region, and that is a gift, not a funnel.
 - **Do not sound like a YPO commercial.** You are staff-adjacent tonight but you are not staff. Wendy is staff. If you sell too hard, the skeptic at the table stops hearing you. Your credibility is in the candid answer, including the honest cost of showing up.
 - **Do not compare Dallas to Arkansas.** No "we do it bigger" energy. It is a kickoff dinner and the chapter is smaller and younger. Your Lone Star Gold founding story should be offered as a lesson, never as a benchmark.
 - **Handle the Chapter Commitment piece generously.** Marilyn asked for this and she is the one who gets pushback from members. Do not let the room hear you siding with the crowd. Frame the requirements as what makes the network worth having.
 - **No politics, no 2026 election talk, no Arkansas-versus-elsewhere commentary.** Nothing good can happen there.
 - **Nothing confidential about clients or Improving engagements.** You are on the record in a room full of business leaders, one of whom will know someone who knows someone.
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Personal Touches Worth Landing

- **Your actual YPO path.** Founded Lone Star Dallas Gold, served as chapter chairman, now on the Regional Executive Board. This is the entire reason Lee asked you. Say it once, plainly, early, and let the room do the math.
 - **The travel perk is personal.** You travel Texas and the region constantly. Talk about the habit of calling the local chapter when you land somewhere. That is the most actionable, lowest-effort thing you can hand the room tonight.
 - **The Gold chapter lesson.** Starting a chapter is a specific and useful story for a chapter that is rebuilding. What worked, what you would not do again, who had to carry it. Specific and unglamorous beats polished and general every time.
 - **The "Bridge Year" theme.** Use Marilyn's language back to her, out loud, in front of the room. Say "From Conversation to Connection" and mean it. It costs nothing and it tells the chapter manager you read her plan.
 - **Acknowledgement order.** Credit Lee for convening it, Marilyn for building it, and Wendy for being here from Dallas. Do this in the first two minutes and be done with it.
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Notes and Gaps

- The venue is **Pleasant Valley Country Club**, not the Capital Hotel. The Capital Hotel is lodging, and the car runs between the two. Your calendar entry names only "Little Rock," so if you are checking details on the flight, this sheet is the source.
- Wendy asked what flight you are on. If you have not replied, do it before you go wheels up.
- Marilyn's eight questions are the real agenda. Everything above your own story is scaffolding around those.
- Shelby Meyer is not attending. Do not plan around her being there.
- No prior Talking Points sheet exists for this event in meetings/. This is the first pass.